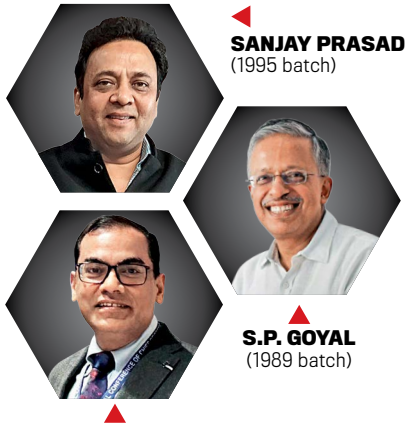


POWER CORRIDOR M.K. Singh (right), a 1988-batch IAS officer, after signing an MoU with a Mexican delegate as CM Yogi Adityanath looks on, Aug. 6



SANJAY PRASAD (1995 batch)

S.P. GOYAL (1989 batch)

ALOK KUMAR (1998 batch)

nopolise power or indulge in any sort of self-branding. Other senior bureaucrats in Yogi's good books include Shashi Prakash Goyal (1989 batch), Anurag Srivastava (1992), Amrit Abhijat (1995) and Alok Kumar (1998). Goyal, popularly known as SPG, has been in the CMO for over six years and has gained in stature after Awasthi's and now Sehgal's retirement. An additional chief secretary, he is also handling the civil aviation, estate and protocol departments. Alok Kumar, an IIT Kanpur alumnus, is overseeing the progress of Yogi's ambitious target of making UP a $1 trillion economy by 2027 as the project's nodal officer, besides discharging his responsibilities as principal secretary, planning & programme implementation. During his stint in the CMO, say sources, Alok Kumar also gave key inputs to Yogi on Covid-19 management.

For a state that has drought-stricken regions like Bundelkhand despite the Ganga and its multiple tributaries dotting the landscape, managing water resources assumes significance. And for planning and monitoring all water-related projects—Namami Gange, minor irrigation, groundwater, rural drinking water, and such—Yogi has chosen Srivastava, a principal secretary in the UP government. Another key focus area for the CM is developing the state's key cities and towns, and Abhijat is overseeing this mission as principal secretary, urban development, urban employment & poverty alleviation.

Besides these senior IAS officers, Yogi has also shown confidence in a few young ones, who have been tasked with executing his big-ticket announcements. For instance, Nitish Kumar (2010 batch) and Divya Mittal (2013). As district magistrate (DM), Nitish Kumar is monitoring several development projects in Ayodhya, the state's most important district in terms of spiritual tourism—more so, with the construction of the Ram temple going on in full swing. Another officer, Vishal Singh, who holds two key charges—municipal commissioner, Ayodhya, and vice-chairman, Ayodhya Development Authority—is helping him in this endeavour. Mittal, on the other hand, had been overseeing Yogi's other dream project—the beautification of the Maa Vindhyavasini Temple—as the Mirzapur DM. In a recent rejig, though, she has been transferred from the district. An IIT and IIM alumna, Mittal is quite popular on social media as well, where she regularly posts motivational quotes.

Meanwhile, Vijay Kiran Anand of the 2009 batch has been given the responsibility of transforming school education. Currently, director general of school education (DGSE) and director of the Mid-Day Meal Authority, he is also the mela officer for the Prayag Kumbh Mela and served as the Gorakhpur district magistrate in 2021-22.

Any appointments in Gorakhpur are keenly watched. For, Yogi not only represented it in the Lok Sabha for two decades (1998-2017) but also happens to be the *mahant* (chief priest) of the Gorakhnath Math even now. Having entered the UP assembly after getting elected from Gorakhpur Urban in 2022, the CM now wants to turn the city into an industrial hub. And a young IAS officer—Pavan Agarwal of the 2015 batch—is his choice to realise this vision. Serving as CEO of the Gorakhpur Industrial Development Authority (GIDA), the IIT Bombay alumnus has his work cut out for him. But the feat really is that he's already there. ■